to publish right away. *Der Spiegel* meanwhile was trying to be friends with everyone. The truth is, we weren't ready to go, as I said, and we were being strong-armed by these people who had been niggling away at us for weeks, and were now ready with the *coup de grâce*. At the centre of their colossal, stained vanity, they had forgotten who we were and how we had got to this room. They now thought of us as a bunch of weird hackers and sexual delinquents. But we knew our material and we knew our technology; these guys were playing by the oldest rules in the business. I implied that I would immediately give the entire cache of material to the Associated Press, Al Jazeera and News Corp. I didn't want to do it, but I would if they didn't play ball.

They sobered up and began to speak more reasonably about how the publication might be handled. I continued my counterattack, pointing out that I would sue them for breach of contract. My organisation was not-for-profit; we depended on donations to pay our costs, and the fact that our systems were not ready for publication when the news hit would mean that our own revenue would take a beating. They had to realise what they were doing to us: we were not a theoretical grouping but a flesh-and-blood organisation who had worked for years to achieve great goals. What they were doing would threaten to destroy us and I would use everything in our power to prevent it. So we began negotiating. They wouldn't budge at first from imminent publication, but eventually we agreed that a month's delay would give us just enough time to prepare. I insisted at that point that *El País* and *Le Monde* join the mix of 'media partners', that phrase so hated by the *New York Times*. We now knew, more than they, how grubby partnership could be, and, on the spot, I was making ready for a future in which lessons had been learned.

I stressed that the leak should not be the story – we were in the business of leaking stories themselves, and therefore, to keep the heat off us and on the actual material, I insisted we let the stories out one by one. Top stories first, none about Israel, none about Cuba, allowing the possibility that the US wouldn't simply overreact to Cablegate as a whole. They would attend, as they should, and as we all should, to one leak at a time. I also insisted, as part of this enforced repackaging of our relationship, that the *New York Times* agree to stop their rubbishy, self-serving campaign of writing stories against me and against Bradley Manning, a young man they had characterised as a mad, bad and sad little fag. This no doubt kept the